

Judy Marks, 59, Chair, CEO and President of Otis Worldwide Corporation, has dealt with a host of challenges in her long career. After stints at IBM, Lockheed Martin and Siemens AG, she joined Otis in 2017, where she helped the pioneer of elevator tech become a publicly listed company, following its spin off from United Technologies. In a freewheeling conversation with *Business Today's* **Krishna Gopalan** at the company's design centre in Hyderabad, Marks outlines how her company is positioned today, the difficult period it faced during the Covid-19 pandemic, and why it is a good time to be in the business. Edited excerpts:

Q: You first dealt with customers at your father's store. You were really young then...

A: I am the youngest of three children and we all worked in the store. This wasn't a big chain, but it was meaningful. I started with gift wrapping and still haven't mastered it! Then, I worked behind the counter and made that connection with customers—listening to what they want, what they are interested in, and then trying to fulfil all of it. Be it that one transaction or leading a [big] company with a global customer base, it's that same connection and fulfillment that I have tried to instil in our teams. Our customers understand we're not going to be perfect, but it's that ability to continue to communicate, to share our progress and really listen to what they need that is important.

Q: You are a big believer in informality, especially within teams. Why is that so important?

A: We're all in this together. While there may be organisational layers, we're all serving customers and we're all driving innovation. At Otis, we try to be the best service company in the world. We have 34,000 of our colleagues providing field service every day without supervision. They wear our brand on their uniform and each of them must feel engaged to be in the business.

Q: After stints at some of the biggest

multinationals, what brought you to Otis?

A: I've had the privilege of working for great multinationals, all of which were very focussed on a mission—whether it was Lockheed Martin, which has a national security mission, or Siemens, which has more of a global industrial mission in electrification automation.

What attracted me to Otis was the iconic brand that had sustained for 165 years as an industry leader. I believed I could take everything from my previous experiences and apply them to an industrial company that had an incredible impact on the world.

For me, it's about impact and driving it.

Q: How did you go about tackling the challenges at Otis when you took charge?

A: For Otis, 2017 was the seventh straight year of no earnings growth. The conglomerate had grown but Otis had not. We are in 200 countries with 1,400 branch offices and I travelled extensively to meet our people.

I'll use two words to describe my feeling after the first trip around the world—humble pride. Here was a group of people that was very proud of what it did while living within the constraints of a conglomerate. Otis had not been invested in to the level it needed, but for our colleagues, they were going to provide the best service. This “no earnings growth” was unacceptable. It was a question of giving that commitment back to our customers and putting together a strategy for the company that would be shared with everyone and articulated.

From a foundational point of view, we have three absolutes in this company—safety, ethics and quality—with no compromise on any of those. We're in the life-safety business. It's a hazardous business with people working at heights. We have 2 billion people a day who trust that our products will be safe, effective and reliable. You cannot look at a chart and say, ‘Oh, we did 12 per cent better than last year.’ The only answer is zero—zero fatalities, zero serious incidents. It's not about improving, but only about getting that zero.

Towards the end of 2018, our former parent's board of directors made the decision to spin off Otis. 2019 was a year to prove to ourselves that we were ready to turn the company around. For the first time, we held ourselves accountable for each quarter, since we were going to be a public company. A lot was done and we entered 2020 feeling energised and excited. And then I started getting calls in late January [2020] from China on the pandemic. It was a defining moment and also one of great resilience. We were an essential service and our colleagues, whether in manufacturing or service,